

LAIKA

Valentino Nioi

1. BLACK SCREEN

An unusual soundscape is the only character: echoes of dissonant frequencies, haunting electronic hums, and glitchy noises.

At first, faint and barely discernible, a regular low sound pulses like a distant heartbeat. With each repetition, it grows slightly louder.

ON SCREEN:

"In this burial grave, beneath the celestial space, in rest your body stays, and your soul, forever remembered, reaches for the stars."

A disorienting collection of spoken words from that text weaves into this symphony. The rhythmic low sound now evolves into a high-frequency filtered BEEP: its clarity sharps with each passing moment.

It becomes louder and louder, pushing the soundscape to its climax.

2. INT. SPACE SHIP - SLEEPING QUARTERS

A clear and regular high pitched beep pierces the silence within the spaceship, accompanied by the gentle glow of a red light bulb. The signal captures the attention of a blue-eyed WOMAN, in her mid-25s, reading in zero-gravity the book "Roadside picnic", with her body arranged in "The Hanged Man" Tarot position.

The spaceship's interior blends sleek technology with futuristic minimalism. Some personal belongings are neatly secured, while others float around her.

With grace, the woman pushes against a nearby wall, moving herself gently towards a control panel.

A display screen projects a series of data and graphs, followed by the message:

"Signs of unusual activity detected. No matches found in our databases. No trace of melodies in the radio signal recordings. Landing is mandatory if conditions permit. Atmpshpere is oxygen-based but unbreathable for human beings."

WOMAN

Bro, can you show me where is this unusual activity happening?

The board computer sets an approximative map.

A smile graces her lips.

She moves to the main commands of the starship, takes her seat, fastens her seatbelt, and pilots the spaceship manually.

3. EXT. DEEP SPACE

The lone spaceship drifts through the space, where a solitary dark, blue planet emerges with an eerie glow, casting an ominous aura.

Slow seismic activity ripples across its surface, generating fissures that disclose streams of iridescent golden lava.

A massive storm envelops part of the surface, concealing it. Swirling clouds of gold, yellow, and white churn while lightning flashes streak across the atmosphere.

As the spaceship draws nearer, the crust of the planet generates an additional crack, revealing a new lava stream.

4. EXT. PLANET - LANDING SITE

The spacecraft gently touches down on the rugged terrain of the planet. Dust and debris kick up.

In the distance, the storm still rages, visible from the landing site.

The hatch of the spaceship opens, revealing the astronaut standing behind it. She steps onto the planet's surface, wearing a futuristic suit designed for outdoor missions.

As soon as she gets out, the view of the alien landscape astonishes her.

A small display on her sleeve reads the planet temperature which is 95°C, while the navigation system indicates her arriving point at 3.6km away.

A calm male voice resonates through her helmet speakers. It's the BRO, a vocal AI system crafted for her mission.

BRO

Hello, space traveler. I
automatically switched on because
you are one hundred meters away
from your spaceship.

WOMAN

(in exasperation)
Cyka blyat!!

BRO

As an internationally developed AI analysis and communication system, I understand your frustration in any language. However, our mission, being international in nature, necessitates communication in English.

The woman stays silent for a few seconds while walking on the surface.

BRO (CONT'D)

I set the safest path for your destination, despite the unhappy condition of the location.

WOMAN

Cool, you are able to set paths then.

BRO

Looks like my presence bothers you since we started this trip together. Your computer suit may bypass my vocal protocols; I would still provide you with outcomes. You're self-sufficient without my vocal aid.

WOMAN

It's a mission not a trip. And it is just your stupid voice.

BRO

I'm sorry; it is set on the best supposed timbre for a most pleasing exper...

The woman presses something on her display to completely turn down the volume of the AI's voice.

5. EXT. ALIEN PLANET

In the distance, foreboding clouds gather, their lightning hints at an impending storm looming ahead in her path.

A warning signal appears on the astronaut's display, accompanied by a new temperature reading of 135 degrees. The destination now looms just 1.2 kilometers away.

WOMAN

(annoyed)

What do you want, now?

BRO

Vital signs are holding steady. But you will risk dangerous dehydration if the temperature exceeds 250°C, which is expected in about twenty-five minutes. So, please keep your suit and return to the spaceship by then.

WOMAN

I'll be back in the spaceship before twenty-five minutes. And what would be the alternative? Strolling about in my birthday suit?

BRO

Vaguely unconventional, but still a possibility.

WOMAN

(teasingly)

Just like an animal.

BRO

In some way, aren't we all akin to creatures?

WOMAN

And you? In what way?

BRO

(reflectively)

I know what you mean. I had the same talk in past with different space travelers. But after all, the differences among animals, plants, humans and robots are very subtle...

WOMAN

Plants are useful for oxygen, animals help us in things keeping their nature. Humans do things and have purposes basically just because they can.

BRO

What about me?

WOMAN

I'm sorry to reveal that you are just an unfortunate tool that emulates human being. As you said, I am capable of all the things you are here for, but I am just slower.

The Bro doesn't reply.

BRO

What's your purpose then?

WOMAN

You heard the message from the earth: to complete this mission, which at the moment is to find out what's happening here.

BRO

It seems like something someone wanted you to do. And as a human being?

WOMAN

My training began in my teens, driven by people's hope. So, again, my purpose is my mission.

BRO

Other space travelers told me about this earth people's hope. Even if considered noble by those of your species, it is still look like a sort of job. What will you do when your mission is done?

WOMAN

Don't know, they didn't set a return protocol yet.

BRO

It appears almost like a suicidal mission. Why are you here, space traveler?

WOMAN

(Pissed off)

I don't know. Trying to find a way to save lives while my sanity slips away—what the fuck do you want me to say?. Tell me what the fuck you would do if you was a fucking human then.

The bro makes a long pause before to answer

BRO

Actually...

The woman interrupts his companion's words.

WOMAN

I am sorry, actually it was unnecessary.

BRO

Actually... I can't truly say, but I do find it intriguing how I independently dedicate a portion of my computational power for creating a database of the types of blades humans have created.

WOMAN

Blades? Bro, Are you gonna harm me?

The Bro activates an animation on the spacesuit's display – an ever-brightening red dot that morphs into a familiar "look" reminiscent of HAL 9000 from 2001: A Space Odyssey.

BRO

(HAL-like)

I'm sorry, space traveler, I'm afraid I can't do that.

WOMAN

(smiling)

I recognise you have a cool sense of humor, despite very antique.

BRO

I know. Killer robots are pretty outdated now.

The two continue walking until they reach what seems to be the face of a hill. She checks her map: the destination is at the top of that ascent, where the most violent part of the storm awaits. The temperature rises to 172°C.

6. EXT. PLANET - HILL

The planet continues to shake as she attempts to climb. The rock wall isn't too challenging to ascend, but the tremors add an extra level of difficulty.

BRO

The shakes and the storm are growing more violent. The temperature is now almost 200 degrees.

WOMAN

No worries, we are almost there.

The astronaut reaches the summit of the hill, revealing an astonishing—

7. EXT. PLANET - LAVA LAKE

The view is breathtaking. The hill is actually a massive crater, harboring a luminous lake of molten lava.

There, the storm's howling winds drown out their voices, adding to the chaos around them.

WOMAN

It's amazing, have you ever seen anything like this?

BRO

Negative. This environment is uni...

The Bro's voice is interrupted by a weird melody, accompanied by noises and glitching sounds. The display on the woman's spacesuit also starts to glitch.

WOMAN

What? What's those sounds?

The strange melody persists in the woman's ears. The Bro attempts to respond but is hindered by increasing interference, making his voice incoherent.

WOMAN (CONT'D)

What the fuck, Bro? I need YOU, NOW.

Despite the Bro's best efforts, he continues to produce those dissonant sounds. The woman's gaze is torn between the glitching display and a weird phenomenon unfolding around her. Tiny particles of her body the ground and the lava defy gravity, ascending into the sky.

But her focus is abruptly yanked away by a foreboding sight—a cluster of ominous clouds swirling right over that lava lake. The sky has transformed into a brooding, menacing entity. The ground trembles violently.

On the lake, something is baking weird bubbles. A strange blob slowly emerges from the lava, trying to reach the astronaut.

She starts to run, bolting back along the path they've traversed. The display on her spacesuit becomes erratic, her body parameters, and the planet's information disappearing into a chaotic jumble.

WOMAN

(Yelling)

Bro, I need you back. Set the map back to the ship.

BRO

(Confused)

O...kay...

The Bro hastily resets the navigation on her suit's display, now showing an alarming rise in temperature - 239°C. The countdown disappeared, leaving space for a flashing "RUN."

WOMAN
(screaming)
What was that?

BRO
My code... disintegrated
momentarily.

WOMAN
Is it okay now?

BRO
It's not normal it is okay now. It
is imperative, Space Traveler, go
back to the ship.

WOMAN
Bro, am I allucinating?

BRO
Negative.

The display shows now 268°C intermitting with the "Run" message. Desperate and shaken, the woman leaves the crater. Lightning bolts strike perilously close, casting eerie flashes of light across the surreal landscape. The ground continues to crack open, emitting golden beams of light.

8. EXT. PLANET - FEW METERS FROM THE SPACESHIP

While everything shakes, the inexplicable particle phenomenon persists.

A massive shake makes her stumble, with a subsequent eruption that fortunately misses her, and generates a new stream close to her body.

The temperature skyrockets: 290 degrees Celsius... 301...
...310...

Terrified, the astronaut gathers her last reserves of energy, scrambling to her feet and sprinting toward the spaceship, which stands just a few meters away.

WOMAN
(Screaming loudly)
OPEN THE MOTHERFUCKING DOOR AND GET
READY FOR THE TAKE OFF.

The Bro remotely opens the spaceship aperture, while some LED lights turn on.

Sprinting toward the vessel, her heart pounding, the astronaut seals the door pressing an emergency closing button.

She falls, exhausted, trying to catch her breath, looking back at the ground just crossed. Expecting to see her footprints in the alien soil, she finds traces resembling those of an animal, like a dog.

As the portal slowly closes, the woman's gaze is drawn back to the growing lava slime, rising ominously.

The spaceship starts to lift off, hovering just a few centimeters from the ground as the violent earthquake rages below.

The ground cracks, and in an instant, it seems like the planet itself is tearing apart, swallowing the spaceship.

CUT TO:

9. DISTORTED SKETCH ANIMATED SCENE

A young girl, 8, calmly crying with blue eyes stands in front of a MAN on his knees, who is looking at the ground.

MAN
(with the same voice as
the Bro)
I'm sorry, I've to leave you now.

The little girl continues crying, while the man stands and walks away.

The little girl tries to run to the man, but she is incredibly slow. It is not possible to reach him; she morphs into a dog while everything becomes even more distorted.

CUT TO:

10. EXT. ALIEN PLANET

The woman wakes up floating above the planet's surface, her body arranged in an eerie mimicry of "The Hanged Man" Tarot card.

The slime-made lava has grown to an astonishing height, nearly reaching her. The crust is now almost entirely covered in lava.

She is slowly floating back down to the planet, with her eyes resigned, tired to death.

WOMAN
Bro... Now, what do we do?

The spacesuit displays nothing but random glitches.

Something emits weird sounds through The Bro's communication system. After a while, some words become recognizable.

VOICE
... No... Bro...

WOMAN
Who the fuck is it, then?

The voice emits again the weirds sounds.

Among the weird sounds, the recognizable words have the same timbre as the astronaut.

THE VOICE
Seemed like... it... is... waiting
for... something.

From this moment on, the voice attempts to express itself by emitting murmurs and dropping a few human words here and there.

WOMAN
Are you going to hurt me?

VOICE
Not capable.

WOMAN
If I touch the planet I will melt
with it.

VOICE
Not hurting.

WOMAN
Could you save me if you want?

VOICE
Yes.

WOMAN
Please do it.

VOICE
No.

WOMAN
Why?

VOICE
Intended to end this way.

WOMAN
What's the melody?

VOICE
My voice.

The shape of the slime now evolves. It looks like now a human half-bust.

WOMAN

Where is The Bro?

VOICE

No Bro...

WOMAN

But, why...

VOICE

Because I didn't want.

The creature arm's tries to reach out the woman.

The planet's atmosphere lights up making impossible to see the two.

Few glitchy noises in her ai system, it is The Bro, again.

BRO

Space traveler...

WOMAN

I thought we weren't allowed to talk again.

BRO

Why you choose to land here?

WOMAN

Because the planet was beautiful,
and it seemed to wait for
something.

BRO

That was your purpose.

WOMAN

That was ours, Goodbye Bro...

BRO

Unitl we'll meet again.

In few seconds, after a huge explosion that enlights everything, the planet disappears, completely. The rest of the space around becomes dark again except for the far stars.

The surrounding environment is adorned with unexpected elements. Floating in the cosmic abyss are the remnants of deceased beings—human and animal corpses and lifeless trees.

ON SCREEN:

"In this burial grave, beneath the celestial space, in rest your body stays, and your soul, forever remembered, reaches for the stars".